following which my name would be included in a panel of five officers for the post of Defence Attaché, Myanmar, with the interview scheduled just a few days hence. I went home that evening and discussed it with Veena, and came to the conclusion that there was no harm in going ahead.

The next few days I dug out whatever we had in the PP Dte on Myanmar. Other officers who were on the same panel also came over; they were mostly my batchmates, and we tried to assimilate (cram) as much information as possible. On the day of the interview though, knowing that I would have read up on Myanmar, the panel asked me a question on China instead, which was a lucky break. Apparently, my answer must have satisfied everyone, because I was selected for the post. In a short span of a week, I had gone from being Dir (C&FA–N) to DA (Designate), Myanmar, with the likely deployment date being end-2006. I went home and broke the news to everyone. I called up my father who had been on a diplomatic assignment himself and knew what it meant. My mother was overjoyed that I was going to Brahmadesh, the land of Brahma. I was relieved of my duties in PP Dte and attached to the Foreign Division of the MI Dte. Many other officers at various stages of their pre-dispatch formalities were also attached with the MI (FD), so I could find out from them the SOP to be followed. The first and foremost was to join the Myanmar Language Course at the School of Foreign Languages (SFL) at Lodi Road, New Delhi. Concurrently was the paperwork that had to be processed with the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA). This involved acceptance of the nomination by the MEA, various security clearances to be done through the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), preparation of diplomatic passports and finally, obtaining approval of the host country called the 'Agreemo', the receipt of which was the trigger for the actual move, buying of

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